

Report conversation

what happens if website doesn't have robots.txt? is it equivalent to having this file with the rules commented out?

```
# See http://www.robotstxt.org/robotstxt.html for
documentation on how to use the robots.txt file
#
# To ban all spiders from the entire site uncomment the
next two lines:
# User-agent: *
# Disallow: /
```

When a website does not have a `robots.txt` file, it generally implies that the webmaster does not explicitly restrict web crawlers and bots from accessing and indexing any part of the site. This is not exactly equivalent to having a `robots.txt` file with the rules commented out.

A missing `robots.txt` file means there are no instructions for web crawlers on how to treat the site's content. As a result, respectful web crawlers (like those operated by major search engines) assume they have permission to crawl and index all content on the site.

On the other hand, having a `robots.txt` file with all rules commented out (effectively no rules) is a clear indication that the webmaster has considered robot access control but has chosen not to implement any restrictions. This is a more explicit statement than not having the file at all, although in practice, the outcome might be the same—web crawlers are free to access all content.

The `robots.txt` file serves as a guideline for web crawlers and not a strict access control mechanism. Well-behaved crawlers follow the instructions specified in `robots.txt`, but it's worth noting that not all crawlers respect these rules. Therefore, sensitive or private content should not rely on `robots.txt` for protection.

